The 44 sounds of English

A key word for every sound, with the letters that spell it marked: consonants in black, *sh, ch* and *th* in green, vowels in red. A bar under two or more letters marks a single sound. The symbols are from the International Phonetic Alphabet, so /j/ is the *y* in *yes*, and the *j* in *jam* is /dʒ/.

24 consonants

The mouth closes or narrows somewhere. Each label says how.

stops the mouth closes, then lets go	**p**ig /p/	**b**at /b/	**t**op /t/	**d**og /d/	**k**it /k/	**g**um /g/
fricatives the air squeezes through a narrow gap	**f**ish /f/	**v**an /v/	**th**in /θ/	**th**is /ð/	**s**un /s/	**z**ip /z/
	hat /h/	**sh**ip /ʃ/	vi**si**on /ʒ/			
affricates a stop that slides into a squeeze	**ch**in /tʃ/	**j**am /dʒ/	Each begins as a stop and ends as a squeeze: *t* into *sh* in *chin*, *d* into *zh* in *jam*.			
nasals the mouth closes and the air goes out the nose	**m**ap /m/	**n**et /n/	ri**ng** /ŋ/			
liquids and glides the mouth barely closes	**l**eg /l/	**r**ed /r/	**w**eb /w/	**y**es /j/		

20 vowels

The mouth stays open, and the tongue and lips shape the sound.

short vowels	c**a**t /æ/	b**e**d /ɛ/	s**i**t /ɪ/	h**o**t /ɑ/	c**u**p /ʌ/
long vowels long u often sounds like the oo in moon	d**ay** /eɪ/	s**ee** /i/	m**y** /aɪ/	g**o** /oʊ/	m**oo**n /u/
other vowels	b**oo**k /ʊ/	s**aw** /ɔ/	**a**bout /ə/		
diphthongs	b**oy** /ɔɪ/	c**ow** /aʊ/	The vowel slides from one shape to another. The long vowels in *day, my* and *go* slide too.		
r-controlled vowels	c**ar** /ɑr/	f**or** /ɔr/	h**er** /ɝ/	h**air** /ɛr/	**ear** /ɪr/

About the count. Forty-four is a teaching count, and it shifts with accent. Many Canadians say *hot* and *saw* with the same vowel, which takes one away. Count *car, for, hair* and *ear* as a vowel followed by *r*, and four more go, which leaves 39. Check this sheet against your program's sound wall.

Over: marking a word

Marking a word

Vowels are red, consonants black, and *sh, th* and *ch* green. Say the word slowly, count its sounds, then mark it by hand. Use the colours and marks selectively: choose the ones that show a pattern or how two marks interact, especially in a new word.



Sound circle

A circle under each sound: red for a vowel, black for a consonant, green for *sh, th, ch*.



Syllable swoop

A swoop under each syllable.



Short mark

A cup over a vowel that keeps its short sound.



Long mark

A bar over a vowel that says its name.



No mark

A lone vowel with no cup and no bar borrows another vowel's sound, or is said weakly.



Bond bar

A bar under the letters of a single sound. All the letters of a vowel sound are red.



R-controlled unit

A red bar under a vowel and its *r*. The *r* stays black, and they share a circle.



Cone of silence

A dotted ring around a silent *e*.



Vowel vault

An arc from a silent *e*, or from a vowel one consonant later, back to the vowel it makes long.



Morpheme seam

A dotted line between the parts of a word that carry meaning.





Block box

A box around a pair that stops a vowel after it from reaching back, such as *ll, nn, ck, tch* or *dg*. *Block* has a bar: nothing reaches yet. *Blocked* keeps it, and the box stops the *e*'s vault, so the *o* stays short.





Nice-nudge

A small arc from *e, i* or *y* to a *c* it softens, or from a final *e* to a *g*. In *nice* the *e* also makes the *i* long. In *nudge* a box stops that vault, so the *u* stays short.



Blocked vault

The arc ends in a red X where a box stops it, so the vowel stays short.

Contrasts



The same letter three ways: short, long, and borrowing another vowel's sound.



The same two sounds, spelled with four letters and with two.



In *gave* the silent *e* makes the *a* long. In *give* it only keeps *v* off the end.



After a single *n* the *y* reaches back and the *u* is long. A doubled *n* in a box stops it.

Over: the 44 sounds of English